

Almost

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Abstract

What is it for something to almost happen? The standard answers say that “almost ϕ ” is true when ϕ is false but true in some possible world that closely resembles the actual one, or when the actual value lies close below ϕ on a scale. I argue that both measure closeness in the wrong place. For events, “almost ϕ ” is true when a process of the kind the prejacent names was under way and a perturbation of it, no larger than the variation the process undergoes from moment to moment, would have produced a course that stayed as close as that to the actual course for as long as the actual course lasted and then ended in ϕ . This is a nearby-worlds account with a metric: the worlds are courses of the actual process, and their distance is the largest deviation between them, measured in the process’s own moment-to-moment variation. It explains why equal distances from an outcome can be unequal near-misses, why closeness without a process is a poor case of almost, why what a mechanism was disposed to do does not make it almost do it, and why “almost” can be true of a project abandoned far from its goal. For scalar and stative uses the account reduces to a directed scalar semantics, and I say what fixes the direction and where it can reverse. The account also separates “almost” from “could easily have.” The second requires only that a small perturbation of the process’s start would have led to ϕ ; the first requires that the perturbed course stayed close throughout; and the two come apart at the lottery, where a small change in the mixing would have drawn any ticket and the drawing approached few. The safety condition on knowledge uses the second. The proximity test in the law of attempts, ordinary talk of lucky escapes, and the regret of the person who almost made it use the first.

I Near-misses

Things almost happen. The bridge almost collapsed; she almost caught the train; he almost said yes; the ball almost went in; it is almost three o’clock; almost everyone came. A good deal turns on such descriptions. The person who almost died is entitled to relief, and the person who almost killed her to guilt; the runner who almost won has a different evening from the one who was never in contention; the law of attempts asks how close a defendant came; and epistemologists say that you know only if you could not easily have been wrong. So there is a question here that is not only about a word. What is it for something to almost happen?

There are two ready answers. On the first, which descends from Lewis’s (1973) treatment of counterfactuals and which the first semantic treatments of the word took over (Sadock 1981; Rapp and Stechow 1999; Morzycki 2001), what almost happened is what happens in a possible world that closely resembles the actual one. On the second (Hitzeman 1992; Penka 2006; P. Amaral and Del Prete 2010),

what almost happened is what lies a short distance further along a scale: “almost 100 people came” is true iff fewer than 100 came and the number is close to 100. One answer measures closeness by resemblance among worlds, the other by distance on a scale.

I will argue that both measure it in the wrong place. For events, “almost ϕ ” is true when a process of the kind the pre-jacent names was under way and a perturbation of it, no larger than the variation the process undergoes from moment to moment, would have produced a course that stayed as close as that to the actual course for as long as the actual course lasted and then ended in ϕ . Call this the *close-course account*. It is a nearby-worlds account with a metric. The worlds are courses of the actual process; their distance is the largest deviation between them at any moment, measured in the process’s own moment-to-moment variation; and “almost ϕ ” says that a ϕ -course lies within a unit. The structure is the one that Lewis’s (1979) weights on similarity were chosen to imitate (Elga 2001; Bennett 2003) and that Kvart (1986) made explicit, a match of histories followed by a small divergence; what the account adds is that the divergence must stay small until the actual course ends. That is what separates a near-miss from an outcome that was merely near. A ball that stops short of a target because a wall is in the way, a jumper who lands ten centimetres short after stumbling on the board, a loaded die that comes down on two: each ends close to the outcome, and for none of them is there a course ending in the outcome that stays close to the actual course all the way. For scalar and stative uses the word reduces to a directed scalar semantics, and I will say what fixes the direction.

The two ideas in the account are not new. Two psychologists said thirty-five years ago that the close counterfactual “does not invoke an alternative possible world, but states a fact about the history of this world” (Kahneman and Varey 1990, 1101), and two others have shown that judgments of what almost happened track the size of the perturbation that would have changed the outcome rather than how near the outcome was, and built a model on which “almost” is the probability of the outcome under noisy re-simulation of the actual event (Gerstenberg and Tenenbaum 2016; Gerstenberg et al. 2021). What has not been done is to state this as the meaning of the word in a form definite enough to be tested against the data the semantics literature has assembled, to say what the perturbation is a perturbation of and when it counts as small, to show that the account covers the scalar uses the psychologists set aside, and to draw the consequences for the parts of philosophy that trade in nearby possibility. The consequence I care most about is that “almost” and “could easily have” turn out to be different relations. “Could easily have” requires only that a small perturbation of the process’s start would have led to ϕ ; “almost” requires that the perturbed course stayed close throughout; and the two come apart at the lottery, where a small change in the mixing would have drawn your ticket but no drawing ever approached it. Safety epistemology needs the second; the law’s proximity test for attempts, ordinary talk of lucky escapes, and the regret of the person who almost made it use the first; and the idiom of close possible worlds, in which all of these are usually put, runs them together.

§2 sets out five things near-misses are like. §3 says why the standard pictures cannot capture them. §4 states the account and runs the cases. §5 answers objections, chiefly the claim that “almost” can be true “at a distance” (McKenzie and Newkirk 2020). §6 draws the consequences.

2 What near-misses are like

2.1 They are directed

“Almost 100 people came” is false if 103 came. “It is almost three o’clock” is false at 3:05. “The glass is almost empty” is false of a glass with one sip taken. “He is almost ten” is false of an eleven-year-old. The near-miss lies on one side of ϕ , and which side is fixed. But it is not always fixed in the same way. Sadock observed that “it is almost zero degrees” can be said of a temperature just above zero when it is getting colder and just below when it is getting warmer P. Amaral and Del Prete (2010). Nouwen (2006, 171) offers a man in a time machine, watching a clock read 3:05, who can say “it is now almost three o’clock.” Amaral and Del Prete (2010, 56–58) note that “the Pope is almost in Rome” says he is heading toward Rome and cannot be said of someone who left it yesterday.

Two things are visible here. By default, the side on which “almost ϕ ” lies is the side from which the scale is canonically traversed: counting goes up, ageing goes up, time goes forward, emptying goes down. And a salient process running the other way can override the default at some points and not at others. A clock running backward makes 3:05 almost three; a room emptying through 103 lets one say “almost 100 people are here”; but no process makes a glass being filled through ten per cent “almost full,” and a room filling through three is still almost empty. The points that can be overridden are interior points; the endpoints, “empty,” “full,” “all,” “none,” cannot be.

2.2 They track effort, not outcome

Nouwen (2006, 167–68) asks us to suppose that six metres qualifies for the long-jump final. Travis almost qualified if he jumped 5.90 and did not if he jumped 2.00, and the predicate “qualify for the final” has no scale with points between: “the set of qualifiers is irrelevant to the truth of *Travis almost qualified*. The only thing that matters is Travis’ efforts” (Nouwen 2006, 168). Take the point further. Two jumpers land at 5.90. One took off from the board at speed and was carried there by a jump that a slightly faster run-up would have carried past six metres. The other took off badly, from a stumble, and reached 5.90 only because the sand was soft. Both are ten centimetres short. The first almost qualified; the second did not. What differs is not the distance from the threshold but what the jump was.

Kahneman and Varey (1990, 1105) make the point with a footrace. On the last lap, one runner is in contention and is known to have a strong finish; another has been catching up rapidly with the leader; both lose by the same amount. Of the first it will not do to say that he almost won with a strong finish “if in fact he or she showed no evidence of talent on that particular occasion”; of the second, who was closing, “almost won” is apt. They call what the second runner displayed a *propensity*, “what is learned about the probability of an outcome from observing event cues,” as against a *disposition*, the probability of the outcome assessed in advance (Kahneman and Varey 1990, 1104). Covey and Zhang (2014) confirm the pattern: losing a best-of-three on the third toss after two heads feels closer than losing it after a head and a tail, and a horse that stumbles while catching the leader is judged to have been nearer to winning than one that finished the same distance back after trailing throughout.

2.3 Proximity without approach is not enough

Kahneman and Varey asked subjects to rate “Mark almost won the tournament,” where Mark, a far stronger player than anyone entered, had missed the registration deadline by a day; 97 per cent found it “very peculiar” and none found it appropriate (Kahneman and Varey 1990, 1104). A die loaded to show six four times in five showed a two: “the die almost showed six” was rejected by 77 per cent. In each case a nearby alternative is available on any resemblance measure, and a high prior probability besides; “a strong belief in the counterfactual conditional ‘Mark would have won if he had played’ is not sufficient to support the close counterfactual ‘Mark almost won’” (Kahneman and Varey 1990, 1104). Amaral’s “#Pedro almost missed the train, but he never went to the station” (P. M. Amaral 2007, 147) is the same datum in linguistic form.

The case that will matter most is the lottery. Ten tickets in a hat, one drawn, not yours. You could easily have won: one chance in ten. Did you almost win? Nothing about the draw was heading toward your ticket, so far as you know; it was in the hat with the others until another came out. Doan, Denison and Friedman (2024) tested a case of this shape with scratch cards on which four matching symbols win, three have been revealed, and the unrevealed squares hold either no fourth symbol or several. Their subjects’ “almost” ratings rose sharply between the impossible cards and the possible ones and then barely rose as the number of winning squares increased, sitting near the middle of the scale, while their “easily could have” ratings rose in proportion to the odds. “Almost,” they concluded, is about possibility and “easily could have” about probability. I will argue in §6 that this is the signature of two relations, one of which the scratch card cannot instantiate.

2.4 Equal distances can be unequal near-misses

Gerstenberg and Tenenbaum (2016) showed subjects a ball tossed toward a target region and stopping short. In some scenes a wall stood between the ball’s resting place and the target, so that reaching it would have required not a slightly harder throw but a much harder one, over the wall. With the ball stopping at the *same* distance from the target, agreement that it almost reached the target was lower when the wall was present. A model measuring spatial distance fit the judgments with $r = .82$; a model that re-ran the throw in a physics engine and computed “the minimum additional impulse to the throw that would have been required to get the ball into the target region” fit them with $r = .94$. “Something almost happened, when a small perturbation to the relevant causal event would have been sufficient to bring it about.”¹

2.5 The impossible is never almost

If a process could not have reached ϕ , nothing almost ϕ ’d. It is not correct to say of a tethered climber who falls that he almost fell to the bottom of the cliff, nor that Tom almost rolled six sixes if one

¹Gerstenberg and Tenenbaum also found that when a second ball failed to collide with the first, subjects denied that it almost *caused* the outcome even when a small perturbation to its path would have produced the collision, and they attribute this to a further requirement on “almost caused”: the candidate cause “must have actually made a difference.” The account below is an account of “almost ϕ ” for event predicates, and “almost caused” adds a condition on causation that it does not address; I flag the case as one the account does not cover rather than one it fits.

die had been altered so that it could not show six (Kahneman and Varey 1990, 1106); and Doan and colleagues' impossible cards sat at the floor of the scale. On any resemblance measure a world in which the die is unaltered is a very similar world. What makes “almost” false is that no course of the process that ran ends in ϕ .

3 Two pictures, and where they fail

Everyone agrees that “almost ϕ ” has a *polar* component, ϕ is false, and a *proximal* component, ϕ came close (Horn 2002); the polar component is generally taken to be an entailment that is backgrounded and inert (Horn 2002; Nouwen 2006; Kilbourn-Cerón 2017), and nothing here turns on it.

On the *resemblance picture*, “almost ϕ ” is true at w iff ϕ is false at w and true at some w' that differs minimally from w ; Morzycki (2001, 315) gives the picture a comparative closeness ordering. It gets one thing right: “almost” is intensional, and Travis's near-miss is not a fact about who qualified. But resemblance among whole worlds has no direction, so it cannot say why 103 is not almost 100 or why the time machine reverses the verdict; it cannot tell the good jump from the stumble at the same mark, or the throw with the wall from the throw without; and it counts Mark's tournament, the lottery and the altered die as near-misses. Morzycki (2001, 322–23) concedes that the “quite intuitive notion” of points on a scale is not reflected, and Penka (2006, 277–78) shows that, unconstrained, the picture makes “almost every plant is dry” true when every plant is slightly moist.

On the *scalar picture*, “almost ϕ ” is true iff ϕ is false and some alternative close to ϕ on the scale associated with the modified expression is true (Penka 2006, 279; P. Amaral and Del Prete 2010, 64–65). It gets direction right for counting, deriving it from the polar component: if 103 coming entails 100 coming, the falsity of “100 came” excludes every higher alternative (Penka 2006, 279). But times do not entail one another, so “almost three o'clock” at 3:05 is left to a contextual choice between oppositely oriented scales (Nouwen 2006, 171), with nothing said about what chooses; and the scale the predicate supplies is often too coarse, since “qualify for the final” has two points. Nouwen's (2006) refinement measures resemblance by the degrees of whatever indirectly settles ϕ , so that 5.90 is ten centimetres from qualifying and 2.00 four metres; that handles the long jump and fails the wall and the two jumpers, since equal distances are equally close by that measure. The picture's real successes are with gradable predicates, where “almost” diagnoses a closed scale (“almost full,” “almost straight,” “#almost tall”) (Rotstein and Winter 2004; Kennedy and McNally 2005), and the account I give keeps those.

The hybrid of McKenzie and Newkirk (2020) is the nearest thing in print to the account I will give. “Almost ϕ ” is true, on their view, iff a “small enough” set of conditions necessary for ϕ failed, and in all normal worlds where that set holds together with what actually happened, “and nothing else intervenes,” ϕ holds; the second clause borrows the inertia of the progressive (Dowty 1979; Landman 1992; Portner 1998). That is a process notion. But their headline is that closeness is not required, since “almost” can be true “at a distance” (“I almost climbed Mount Everest, but I couldn't raise the money”), and their count of missing conditions is made “with no regard to how the event unfolded.”

Counting conditions cannot see the wall: the ball with the wall and the ball without lack the same condition, more force, and their inertial continuations are the same, since both have stopped. I return to their view in §5.

4 The close-course account

4.1 Statement

The account has two clauses, because “almost” has two kinds of preajacent.

Eventive clause. Where ϕ is an event predicate, “almost ϕ ” is true iff ϕ is false, a process of the kind that ϕ names was under way, and there is a state on the actual course of that process and a perturbation of that state, no larger than the process’s local variation, such that the process’s continuation from the perturbed state (i) stays within the local variation of the actual course for as long as the actual course lasts and (ii) ends in ϕ with substantial probability.

The clause needs four things explained: what a process of the kind ϕ names is, what its states and courses are, what its local variation is, and what the two conditions do. A process of the kind ϕ names is one whose completion would *constitute* ϕ , as against one whose completion is a precondition of starting it: a jump attempt for “clear six metres,” since clearing six metres is a way a jump ends; a roll for “show six”; a drawing for “draw your ticket”; a journey to the gate for “catch the flight,” since arriving before the door closes is what catching a flight consists in; a climb for “climb Everest.” Registering for a tournament, raising money for an expedition, and looking for someone to rob are preparations, since their completion is not a way of winning, climbing or robbing but a condition of setting about it. The process’s *states* are the states of the best model of processes of that kind, its *courses* are the paths that model allows through those states, and its *local variation* is the deviation the model’s noise introduces at a moment: a shift in run-up speed at the board, a nudge to a tumbling die from an irregularity in the table, a few minutes’ difference in how a jam clears. This is the moment-to-moment noise of the process and not the accumulated variation between one run and the next, which for a chaotic process is as large as the state space; the difference between the two is what the clause turns on. The distance between two courses is the largest deviation between them at any moment while both last, in units of local variation.

Condition (i) is the closeness requirement, and it is a requirement on the whole of the actual course. A perturbed course that stays within local variation of the actual one until the actual one ends has, at every moment, been where the actual process was, give or take the noise; that is what it is for the actual process to have approached ϕ . For a process whose dynamics are smooth, a small early perturbation produces a course that stays close, so (i) permits the perturbation anywhere; for a chaotic process, a small early perturbation produces a course that leaves at once, so (i) forces the perturbation late, onto a state at which a nudge changes the outcome. Condition (ii) is what makes the account graded and what handles the process that stopped early. Where the actual course ran to completion, the continuation from the perturbed state runs beside it and (ii) asks whether it ends in ϕ ; where the actual course was abandoned, the continuation runs on alone, and (ii) asks how probably a process in that

state, under its own dynamics, reaches ϕ . “Almost” is graded on both: the smaller the perturbation and the higher the probability, the better the near-miss, and a process with no state from which ϕ is reachable makes the sentence false outright.

The clause does not require that the actual course end near ϕ ; that will usually follow, but not always, and the cases where it does not are the wall and the stumble. It does not require that a perturbation of the *start* would have led to ϕ ; that is what “could easily” requires, and the two come apart where an early perturbation leads, by the process’s own dynamics, to a course that diverges widely from the actual one before ending in ϕ . The clause is a nearby-worlds clause. Its worlds are courses of the actual process, which is a restriction, and its metric is a supremum norm in the process’s own units, which is a specification. Lewis’s (1979) similarity ordering, with its preference for a late, small divergence over an early, large one, was designed to reproduce this shape without a metric; Kvart’s (1986) account of counterfactuals as a match of histories up to a branch point is the same shape with the branch point free. The clause fixes what those left open. It is also, for the eventive case, a formalization of Gerstenberg and Tenenbaum’s minimal perturbation, with one difference that matters: their model perturbs the causal event and asks whether ϕ results, and a perturbation to the launch of a chaotic process counts as small on that measure; on mine it fails (i), since what it produces is a course that leaves the actual one at once. The die is where the difference shows.

Scalar clause. Where ϕ is a point or region on a scale, “almost ϕ ” is true iff ϕ is false and the actual value lies within a unit of ϕ at the contextual granularity, on the near side of ϕ , where the near side is the side from which the scale is canonically traversed, unless ϕ is an interior point and a salient actual process is traversing the scale the other way, in which case it is the side that process approaches from.

The scalar clause is the eventive clause with the canonical traversal of the scale in place of a token process: the “course” is the path along the scale toward ϕ , and the actual value’s distance from ϕ along that path is what is measured. I do not claim to derive the canonical directions; that counting goes up and time forward are facts about the scales, and any account must take them as given. What the account explains is the override pattern. A token process can supply a direction because it is a course, and a course can approach an interior point from either side; an endpoint has one side, so no course can approach it from outside the scale, and a glass being filled is approaching “full” from the only side there is. The scalar picture treats “almost” as a test for closed scales, and it is one on this account: “almost tall” fails because “tall” has no endpoint to approach. Compositionally, “almost” takes its prejacent together with a *path*, supplied by the predicate when the predicate carries a scale and by context otherwise, as Penka’s (2006) alternative set and Nouwen’s (2006) dimension are supplied. For “almost every plant is dry” the scale is the count of dry plants, its endpoint is all, and the moisture of the plants is not on the path, which is why Penka’s case comes out right.

4.2 The cases

The wall. The process is a throw; its states are the ball’s position and velocity; its local variation is a small change in either, of the size a hand’s tremor or a bounce introduces. Without the wall, perturb the velocity at release by that much in the direction of the target: the continuation runs beside the

actual trajectory the whole way, since the dynamics of a rolling ball are smooth, and it ends in the target. Both conditions hold. With the wall, the same perturbation produces a course that stops at the wall, and the perturbations that produce a course ending in the target, over the wall, are not within local variation and produce a course that climbs away from the actual one at once. The resting distances are the same and the near-misses are not, and no measure on the resting position sees the difference.

Effort. A jump's states are the jumper's position and velocity, and its local variation is the small change in run-up speed or takeoff angle that a stride or a plant of the foot introduces within a single attempt. For the first jumper, perturb the velocity at the board upward by that much: the flight runs beside the actual one and lands past six metres. For the second, the same perturbation of a stumbling takeoff lands at 5.95, and the perturbations that clear six metres are those that remove the stumble, which is not a nudge to the state but a different state. For the race, the closing runner's states over the final hundred metres are positions with a speed and an acceleration, and a small perturbation of the state at which his kick began, a few strides earlier, produces a course that runs beside the actual one and crosses the line first. The runner with the reputation had, over the same stretch, a state without acceleration, and a perturbation that gives him a surge is not within local variation. His known capacity for a strong finish, the *disposition*, is a fact about the population of his races and not about the states of this one; it enters the account only if it is realized in a state on the actual course, and it was not. That is the line Kahneman and Varey drew between disposition and propensity, and the account draws it in the same place.

The die. A die's states are its position, orientation and angular velocity, and its local variation is the nudge that a table's irregularity or a slight difference in launch introduces. A die is a chaotic system: two courses that differ by a nudge at the launch separate within a bounce or two and land on unrelated faces. So for a loaded die that came down on two, the perturbations that would have produced a six divide into two kinds, and each fails one condition. A nudge at the launch would have produced a six four times in five, but its continuation leaves the actual tumble at once and fails (i). A nudge at the last bounce keeps the continuation beside the actual course, but a die that is coming down flat on two comes down on two under a nudge, and (ii) fails. The loading makes six-courses common among all the die's courses, which is why the die was disposed to show six and why one could easily have rolled it; it does not put any of them within local variation of this roll. A die that teeters on the edge between two and six before toppling is different: at the teetering state, a nudge within local variation sends it the other way, the continuation runs beside the actual course until the moment of toppling, and (ii) is about one half. So "it almost showed six" is true of the teetering die and false of the loaded die that came down on two, which is what Kahneman and Varey found, and the account explains why the loading, which raises the disposition to 0.8, makes no difference to the near-miss. Kahneman and Varey's subjects also rated "John almost won the pot," where the pot turned on that roll, more highly than the sentence about the die (1990, 1104–5). The account gives the two sentences the same verdict, since winning the pot ran through the die, and I have no explanation of the difference to offer beyond the observation that a sentence about John's fortunes is more worth asserting than one about

the die's; that is a cost.

Mark. No tournament was under way for Mark, so there is no process of the kind “win the tournament” names whose states could be perturbed, and the clause is not satisfied. What was under way was a registration, and the account says that Mark almost registered, if that came close, and that “Mark almost won” is false. That subjects rejected it almost unanimously is what the account predicts, and it matters for §5.

The lottery. The process “draw your ticket” names is the drawing, its states are the positions of the hand and the tickets, and its local variation is a small shift in the hand's path. Whether a nudge to some state produces a continuation that stays close and comes out with your ticket depends on the actual course: if the fingers closed on the ticket next to yours, having brushed yours on the way, then a small shift at that state does, and you did almost win; if your ticket was at the bottom of the hat, no nudge does, and you did not. What the account does not deliver is the flat verdict that a losing ticket did not almost win, and I think it should not. What it delivers instead is that the question has an answer that depends on how the drawing went, that for most losing tickets the answer is no, since a drawing of ten tickets passes close to few of them, and that the holder of a losing ticket ordinarily cannot tell. Compare “could easily have won,” which is settled by the odds before the hand goes in and is true of every ticket. The scratch card is a limit of this. Nothing was drawn in the presence of the player; the card was printed. So there is no course of a process to be near, and the eventive clause has nothing to evaluate. The “almost” judgments Doan and colleagues collected, near the middle of the scale for every possible card and insensitive to the odds, are then what one would expect when the clause is being applied to a process that has to be imagined, since imagination supplies the possibility of an approach and nothing about its closeness. The account does not predict those numbers, and I do not claim that it does; what it says is that the clause, applied to the card, consults whether a ϕ -course exists and nothing about the odds, which is the shape of the data, and that the card is not a case in which “almost” has a determinate value.²

The impossible. The altered die and the tethered climber have no ϕ -course at all; the sentence is false outright.

Statives. A golf ball rests an inch from the hole. “The ball is almost in the hole” is true; “the ball almost went in” is false. The stative is a scalar use, the path being the one a putt would follow; the eventive requires a process of the kind “go in” names, and there was none. The pair shows that both clauses are needed and that they are distinct.

²The one-digit-off ticket, which gambling design exploits (Reid 1986; Clark et al. 2009), has a scalar reading that is true: the number was almost the winning number, within a unit on the scale of digits. “I almost won” is the eventive sentence the player infers from it, and the inference is bad, since no drawing approached the number. The account predicts that the feeling should be strongest where a scalar reading is available, in matching digits and symbols, which is where the industry puts it.

4.3 □Almost□ and □approximately□

An approximator (“roughly,” “more or less”) locates a value in a symmetric halo around ϕ with no requirement that ϕ be false, which is why it is not one of the “almost” modifiers (Morzycki 2001, 314–15; Lasersohn 1999). “Almost” locates a path short of ϕ , directed, and requires that ϕ be false because a path that reached ϕ did not stop short. Hence a datum of Sadock’s (1981, 267): “almost exactly three o’clock” can be said at 2:58 or 3:02, though “almost three o’clock” cannot be said at 3:02. “Exactly” converts the prejacet into the endpoint of a scale of distance from three, on which 2:58 and 3:02 sit at the same point one unit short of it; the direction is lost because “exactly” has removed it, not because “almost” has.³

5 Objections

5.1 At a distance

McKenzie and Newkirk’s case against a closeness requirement is a list (2020, sec. 2): “I almost climbed Mount Everest, but (a) I fell ill when I was 200m from the summit; (b) I had to turn around from the last base camp; (c) the weather turned bad halfway up; (d) base camp was inaccessible; (e) I couldn’t get into Nepal; (f) I couldn’t raise the money; (g) I decided not to get off the couch.” The sentence is felicitous throughout, they report, “although less and less so as we go down the list.”

The account accepts part of the gradient and rejects the conclusion. In (a) to (c) a climb was under way, and it was abandoned, so condition (ii) does the work: perturb the state at which the climb stopped by a nudge within local variation, the illness holding off a day, the weather holding, and ask how probably a climb in that state reaches the summit under its own dynamics. From 200 metres, healthy, the probability is high. From the last camp it is lower. From halfway up, in good weather, it is lower again, since a great deal has still to go right, and the clause does not require that each of those things be within a nudge of the actual course, since the actual course had ended; it asks how probable the summit was from where the perturbed course stood. That is the gradient within (a) to (c), and it is a gradient in (ii). In (d) to (g) no climb was under way, and the account says that “I almost climbed Everest” is false in each, however close the preparation came, as “Mark almost won the tournament” is false. The account therefore disagrees with McKenzie and Newkirk about (d) to (g), and I think it should. Their judgments on those cases are their own, and they mark them as degraded; Kahneman and Varey’s subjects, given a case of the same shape, rejected the sentence almost unanimously. What the account predicts is that the preparation sentences do well: “I almost went to Everest, but I couldn’t raise the money” and “Mark almost played in the tournament” should be accepted, since a preparation was under way and came close, and I would expect them to be. So the account offers a test that separates it from McKenzie and Newkirk’s view. On theirs, “I almost climbed Everest, but I couldn’t raise the money” and “I almost went to Everest, but I couldn’t raise the

³The classic three readings of “John almost killed Harry” (Morgan 1969; McCawley 1971; Rapp and Stechow 1999) are, on the account, three processes the prejacet can select, John’s deciding, his act, and Harry’s dying, each with its own courses. This does not bear on whether “kill” decomposes, for which the strongest evidence comes from “again” (Stechow 1996), and I take no stand on that.

money” lack the same conditions and should be judged alike; on mine, the first should do markedly worse than the second, and worse than (a). If a sample judges the two alike, the account’s “under way” requirement is wrong.

5.2 The grain of a process

A process can be described finely or coarsely, and it might seem that the account’s verdicts depend on the choice. Described finely, a die’s tumble is a sequence of bounces, and at the last bounce a six-course may be very near; described coarsely, it is a launch and a result, and no six-course is near a launch that produced a two. The account’s verdicts do not depend on the choice, because the clause is stated over the states of the best model of the process, and a model is not a description we are free to coarsen: a model of a die that has only a launch and a result is a worse model than one with a tumble, and the clause uses the better one. What the clause is hostage to is the local variation of that model, which is an empirical matter about dice and jumps and traffic and not a matter of description. That is where a critic should press, and the account can be wrong there. It says that a few minutes’ difference in how a jam clears is local variation for a journey and that a jam not forming is not; that a few strides’ difference in when a kick begins is local variation for a race and that a surge from a runner who was not accelerating is not; that a nudge at the table is local variation for a die and a different launch is not. Each of those is a claim about how much a process of that kind varies from one moment to the next, and each could be false; the account is committed to them, and they are the kind of thing that can be checked, which is more than the resemblance picture offers.

There is a second worry about “under way,” which is a binary condition in an account that is otherwise graded. The criterion is that the process whose completion would constitute ϕ has begun, and the criterion is not always easy to apply; the account inherits whatever indeterminacy there is in whether driving to the airport is part of catching a flight (it is, since catching a flight consists in arriving at the gate before it leaves) and whether driving around looking for someone to rob is part of robbing him (it is not, since robbing him consists in taking his property, and one has not started taking anyone’s property until one has found him). Those two answers are not chosen for the verdicts they deliver; they follow from what the predicates name, and a critic who thinks the criterion gives the wrong answer for some predicate should say what the predicate names instead.

5.3 Expectation

Gerstenberg and Tenenbaum found that a player who had done badly in practice and then narrowly missed was judged to have almost hit more readily than one who had done well and missed by the same margin. Kahneman and Varey had predicted the reverse, that dispositions become irrelevant in hindsight. The account is compatible with the effect and predicts it under one assumption. The tremor in a shooter’s release is the local variation of her shots; a nudge to the release of a shot that rimmed out is a larger nudge for a shooter whose hands are less steady; and a larger nudge puts more continuations through the hoop. So if subjects took poor practice as evidence of wide variability, the account predicts their judgments; if they took it merely as evidence that scoring was unlikely, the

effect is pragmatic and the account is silent. The experiment that would decide is one that holds practice performance fixed and varies the shooter’s actual dispersion. What the account does not allow is a runner’s reputation for a strong finish to count as local variation in a race in which he was not accelerating, and that is the difference between a disposition that operates in the process and one that does not.

6 What nearly happened

6.1 □Almost□ and □could easily have□

Return to the lottery. You did not, for all you know, almost win; you could easily have won. The account says why these are different and how they are related. “Could easily have ϕ ’d” is true when a perturbation of the process’s *start*, within local variation, would by the process’s own dynamics have led to ϕ with substantial probability: it is condition (ii) applied at the initial state, with condition (i) dropped. Whether that holds is a matter of how probable ϕ was from the start, and no approach is required, since a course that begins close may diverge widely before ending in ϕ . “Almost ϕ ’d” requires (i) as well. The two agree where the process is smooth, so that courses close at the start stay close, and disagree where it is not. The lottery is where they disagree most, since a drawing is designed to make small initial differences produce unrelated outcomes: every ticket could easily have won, and few almost did. The long shot that nearly came off is the disagreement the other way. Doan and colleagues found “easily could have” answering to the odds and “almost” not (Doan et al. 2024); that is consistent with the account, which puts the odds into “could easily” and not into “almost,” though as I said in §4 the card is not a case in which the account assigns “almost” a value.

The safety condition on knowledge says that one knows only if one could not easily have been wrong: in close cases in which one believes as one does, one believes truly (Sosa 1999; Williamson 2000; Pritchard 2005). Among its applications is the verdict that you do not know your ticket will lose (Hawthorne 2004), and to deliver it the condition must use “could easily” and not “almost,” since the losing ticket did not almost win; that is why it is now standardly stated in terms of chance or of a wide class of worlds (Hawthorne and Lasonen-Aarnio 2009; Pritchard 2014). What the account adds is a diagnosis of the best gloss the condition has been given. Sainsbury (1997, 912–14) proposed that “could easily have” be understood through “small differences in relevant parameters” of the actual mechanism, “You would have crashed if the road had been a little more slippery,” and argued with a machine reliable across most of its range that this is not Lewis’s resemblance. He was right, and his gloss handles the lottery, since a small difference in the mixing of the hat is a small difference in a parameter of the mechanism. But it handles it by perturbing the start of the process and not by following its course; it is condition (ii) without (i). Sainsbury’s illustration, the slippery road, is one in which the two conditions agree, since a journey is smooth and a road slightly more slippery produces a course beside the actual one; the lottery, which is his target, is one in which they come apart. So the gloss is right for safety and would be wrong for “almost,” and nothing in the idiom of close worlds marks the difference.

Luck runs the other way. The modal account of luck (Pritchard 2005, 2014) says that an event is lucky iff it occurs in the actual world but not in a wide class of nearby worlds in which the relevant initial conditions are held fixed, and its paradigm is the lottery winner. That is a “could easily” account, and it is right about lucky wins. It is not what Teigen (1996) found people to mean when they told stories about their luck, which were dominated by near-misses of bad outcomes. A lucky escape is an “almost” case with one more condition: a nudge within local variation would have sent the course into the harm, and what kept it out was not the agent’s doing. The pedestrian who dives clear of the bus had a near-miss and was not lucky, since what kept her out was hers; the one who is missed because the driver braked had a near-miss and was. The tethered climber who slips and is caught was not lucky in this sense, since there is no state of his fall from which the bottom is reachable, whatever the modal account says when it fixes the tether among the initial conditions. So the word “luck” is used for two relations, and the nearby-worlds idiom hides the fact, since it can be read either way.

6.2 Attempts

The criminal law punishes attempts and has always needed a line between preparation and attempt. Holmes’s line is proximity: “preparation is not attempt. But some preparations may amount to an attempt. It is a question of degree. If the preparation comes very near to the accomplishment of the act, the intent to complete it renders the crime so probable that the act will be a misdemeanor” (*Commonwealth v. Peaslee*, 177 Mass. 267, 59 n.e. 55 (1901) 1901, 272); there must be “dangerous proximity to success” (*Hyde v. United States*, 225 u.s. 347 (1912) 1912, 388). In *People v. Rizzo* (1927) four men driving around looking for a payroll clerk they meant to rob were held not to have attempted robbery, because they never found him. The Model Penal Code (1962, sec. 5.01) replaced proximity with a “substantial step” that is “strongly corroborative of the actor’s criminal purpose,” and Yaffe (2010) defends the change: attempt liability answers to the defendant’s guiding commitment, not to his distance from the harm.

The account says what the proximity test was a test of, and why it was replaced. To ask whether the defendant came dangerously near is to ask whether he almost committed the crime, and that is a matter of whether a course of conduct whose completion would constitute the crime had begun and how small a perturbation of it would have carried it through. Holmes’s own line between preparation and attempt is the account’s line between preparing and doing, and *Rizzo* is Mark: no robbery was under way, since there was no one to rob, and the proximity test acquitted the defendants for the reason the account gives. The test’s notorious indeterminacy has two sources on the account, one in whether the constitutive course had begun and one in how near it ran, and the second is graded rather than unprincipled. The substantial-step test changed the subject, and the account says to what. Proximity tracks approach; the penal-lottery argument for punishing outcomes, on which the successful attempter may be punished more because the failed attempter’s chance of the greater punishment was matched to the risk he created (Lewis 1989), tracks “could easily,” the probability of harm ex ante; and the substantial-step test tracks neither, but the defendant’s commitment, which is a fact about the agent and not about the course of events. The three come apart in the impossible attempt. The pickpocket who reaches into an empty pocket did not almost steal a wallet, since no state of his conduct is one

from which a theft is reachable; a test that asks how close he came has, on its own terms, no purchase on him, while a test that asks how committed he was does. The proximity-era courts convicted him all the same (*People v. Moran*, 123 n.y. 254, 25 n.e. 412 (1890) 1890; *R v Ring* (1892) 17 Cox CC 491 1892), which shows that the proximity test was never applied as a pure test of “almost” and that the law was already mixing the relations before the Code separated them. Duff (1996) and Yaffe disagree about what the law should say of him; the account says only that the disagreement is about “tried” and not about “almost.”

6.3 Regret

Mr Crane and Mr Tees reach the airport thirty minutes late after the same traffic jam; Crane’s flight left on time, Tees’s was delayed and left five minutes ago; nearly everyone says Tees is more upset (Kahneman and Tversky 1982). Kahneman and Miller (1986) built a theory of counterfactual emotion on such cases, on which an outcome hurts in proportion as its alternative is easy to imagine; Medvec, Madey and Gilovich (1995) found bronze medallists happier than silver medallists. It is tempting to conclude that near-miss regret answers to nothing in the world, since Tees is no worse off than Crane and the alternative is no more available to him.

The account gives a different verdict, and it does not read the verdict off the outcome. The process is a journey to the gate, its states are positions in the traffic at times, and its local variation is the few minutes by which a jam clears sooner or later. Perturb Tees’s course at the jam by that much in the right direction: the continuation runs beside the actual journey, arriving at each point a few minutes earlier, and it ends with him at the gate before the door closes. Crane’s journey needs a perturbation of thirty minutes, which is not the moment-to-moment variation of a journey but the difference between a journey with a jam and one without. The account is graded, and it does not say that Crane’s near-miss is nothing; it says that Tees’s is six times nearer in the process’s own units, and that the difference lies in the courses near each journey and not in the two men’s imaginations. An emotion is fitting when its object has the feature the emotion presents it as having, and near-miss regret presents the course of events as having run within a small variation of the good outcome; Tees’s did, and Crane’s did to a much smaller degree. The same test sorts the gambling cases. On a mechanical machine whose reels stop one by one, two cherries and a spinning third reel is a state from which a nudge sends the continuation to the jackpot, and the near-miss when the lemon lands is genuine; the gambler’s error is not in feeling it but in taking it as a sign about the next spin, which is independent. On a machine whose outcome is drawn before the reels are shown, the display is a picture of an approach that did not occur, and the feeling has no object. And the lorry driver who almost hit the child, whom Williams (1981) and Nagel (1979) compare with the one who did, is not merely someone to whom a bad thing did not happen; a nudge to his driving would have sent it into the child, and “he almost hit the child” is a truth about what he did that the agent-regret Williams describes can answer to.

7 Conclusion

“Almost” reports that a directed path toward something stopped short of it by a small margin. For events the path is a process of the kind the prejacents names, and the account is committed to a claim that can be tested: that a nudge to the process, within its moment-to-moment variation, would have produced a course that ran beside the actual one for as long as it lasted and then ended in the outcome. For scalar and stative prejacents the path is the canonical traversal of a scale, and the account reduces to a directed scalar semantics that says where the direction can reverse. It is a nearby-worlds account whose worlds are the courses of a process and whose metric is the process’s own variation, and what it denies is that worlds are to be ranked by resemblance or values by distance. The two pictures that have dominated the theory of the word each captured a part of this, and neither could say why equal distances can be unequal near-misses, why the word fails when nothing was under way, or why what a mechanism was disposed to do does not make it almost do it. And once “almost” is separated from “could easily have,” which it has been running alongside in the idiom of close possible worlds, the safety condition turns out to use one of them and stories of lucky escapes the other, the law’s proximity test the first and its penal lotteries the second, and the person who almost made it turns out to have something to regret that the person who merely could have does not.

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